

Reproduction

Birds of paradise perform some of the most elaborate courtship displays of all birds, the males attracting females by jumping, hanging upside-down, and making extraordinary noises. However, most passerines have more subtle displays. Many are skilled nest-builders, typically constructing a cup nest from twigs, leaves, and soft material above ground, but they build many more elaborate structures, too. The chicks hatch naked, blind, and helpless, and rely entirely on their parents to feed them until they are ready to leave the nest at 10–15 days old.



ATTRACTING A MATE

Male bowerbirds (such as the spotted bowerbird, left) create elaborate “stages” on which to perform courtship displays. They select a patch of ground, or even build a special structure (the bower), and decorate it with a wide variety of items, such as seeds, grass, and moss, or even human artifacts.

HANGING NEST

Weavers, including the Baya weaver (right), build a highly elaborate domed nest that hangs from a branch, often above water. The nest has an entrance chamber, a nest chamber, and a long tube hanging below. Weavers often nest colonially.



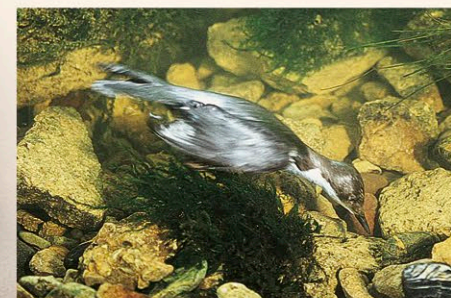
entrance tube

Feeding

Most passerines are small, and therefore require high-energy foods. This means that most species feed either on invertebrates or on seeds, or a combination of the two. Some also take nectar, especially sunbirds. A few rain forest-dwelling families, including birds of paradise, manakins, and cotingas, have an almost exclusive diet of fruit. Among the great variety of passerines are some with more unusual feeding habits. Shrikes are meat-eaters that store their captured prey in a “larder,” impaling the bodies of large insects or small vertebrates on thorns or barbed wire before eating. Crossbills feed only on the seeds of coniferous trees, using their crossed mandibles as tweezers to part the scales of a cone in order to remove the seeds.

USING TOOLS

The woodpecker finch of the Galapagos Islands is one of the few animals that uses tools to catch prey. It picks up a small stick or cactus spine in its bill and uses it to pry insects from crevices in the bark of trees.



UNDERWATER FEEDING

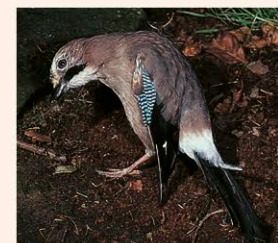
Dippers are among the few passerines to venture into water. When feeding, they dive into shallow, fast-flowing streams, propelling themselves downward with their wings, to catch prey as it swims. They also walk along the riverbed, picking up grubs in their bill.

Anting

A few passerines, including starlings and blackbirds in Europe, indulge in an unusual behavior known as anting, in which a bird collects ants in its bill and rubs them over its feathers. Occasionally, the bird will crouch down and let ants run over its plumage. Birds select only ants that exude formic acid, so it is thought that the habit may help cleanse the feathers of parasites. Also unique to passerines is ant-following, in which birds follow army-ant columns through tropical forest. The birds do not eat the ants themselves, but catch the small insects fleeing the ants' path.

COLLECTING ANTS

A Eurasian jay lies down among a swarm of ants, allowing the insects to crawl through its plumage. The reason for anting is unknown, but it is thought that acid produced by some ants may act as an insect repellent or insecticide, or as a plumage lubricant.



COURTSHIP DISPLAY

Most passerines are monogamous. During the breeding season, a male and female generally form a pair, establish a territory, and build a nest. Among the exceptions to this pattern of behavior are the birds of paradise (such as these Raggiana birds). Males display to females at a breeding arena. After mating, the female builds a nest and cares for her eggs and young alone.